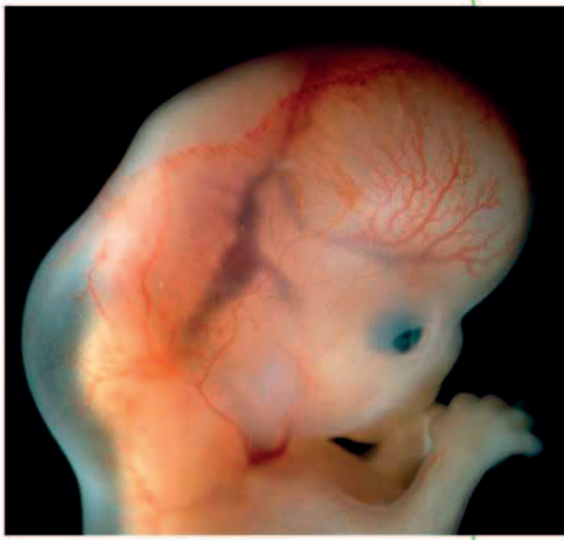
Q What's the nuchal translucency (NT) test?

This is an ultrasound used to estimate the risk of Down syndrome. Although it cannot tell you for certain whether your baby will have Down syndrome, it will inform you if he is at high risk. All women are offered the NT test.

Your baby's nuchal translucency is the pool of fatty fluid beneath the skin at the back of the baby's neck. A sonographer can measure the thickness of the nuchal translucency during an ultrasound at around 11–14 weeks' gestation. After your ultrasound, this measurement is considered in relation to your own age, the baby's length from crown to rump, and the results from the combined blood test (see p.95). Analyzed together, these results can tell you what risk your baby has of being born with Down syndrome.

Comparing the nuchal measurement, your age, and your blood test results has an accuracy of more than 90 percent. Don't worry if your doctor doesn't offer a combined test–a nuchal translucency test combined with your baby's measurements and your age is still a good indicator of risk. If your risk is high, remember that the test is not a diagnosis. You'll be offered diagnostic tests (choronic villus sampling or amniocentesis, see opposite) that will give you a definitive result.



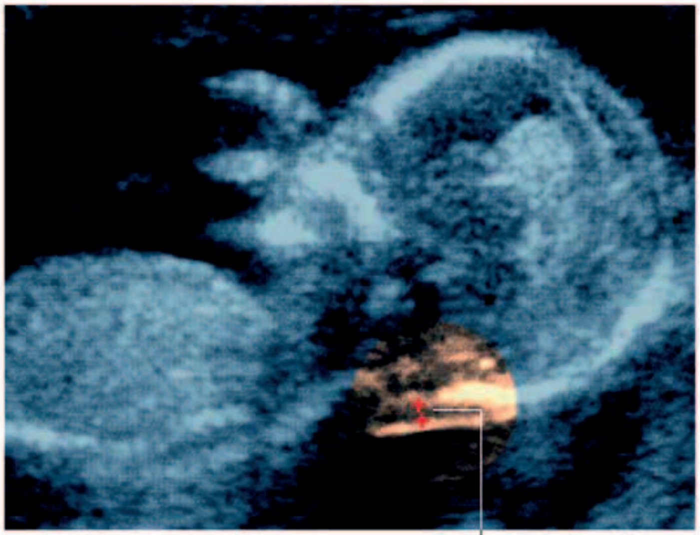
Nuchal fluid While all babies have some fluid at the back of their necks, babies with Down syndrome or other genetic disorders have more. The test is usually scheduled at your 12-week ultrasound.

UNDERSTANDING THE NUCHAL TRANSLUCENCY RESULT

The thicker your baby's nuchal translucency, the greater the risk of your baby having Down syndrome. It is important to note that the measurement is only one part of the test and should be assessed alongside blood test results and your age.

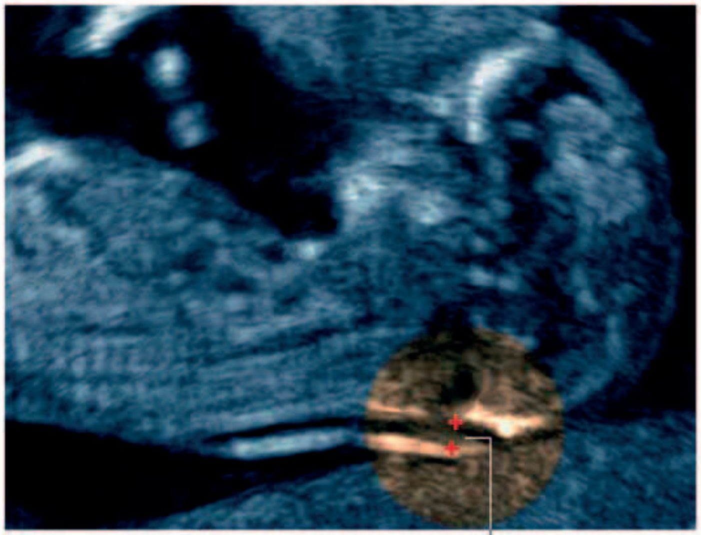
The result is expressed as a ratio. For example, you might be given the result 1:1,500, which means your baby has a one in 1,500 chance of being born with Down syndrome (or, expressed as a percentage, this means a risk of 0.07 percent). A ratio of 1:150 or greater is considered high risk, although even then it's still more likely that you won't have a baby with Down syndrome, (expressed as a percentage 1 in 150 is only a 0.67 percent chance). It's also worth remembering that even if you fall into the low-risk category, there is still a chance (albeit a very slim one) of your baby being born with Down syndrome. If you have a low risk of having a baby with Down syndrome you'll be given the results of the ultrasound within two weeks. If your risk is high, you'll normally get your results within a week, and often within two or three days, so you have as much time as possible to consider whether you would like further diagnostic tests such as an amniocentesis. Whether or not you take these tests is entirely your choice.

When making your decision, keep in mind that some physical indicators of Down syndrome can become apparent at later ultrasounds in your pregnancy, and in these cases your sonographer will tell you what he or she has discovered and what it means in terms of your baby's health.



Low risk If the measurement is under $\frac{1}{16}$ in (2 mm) at 11 weeks, or under $\frac{1}{8}$ in (3 mm) at 14 weeks, your baby is unlikely to have Down syndrome.

Normal nuchal fold



High risk If the nuchal fold measures more than $\frac{1}{8}$ in (3 mm), there is an increased risk of your baby being affected by Down syndrome.

Larger nuchal fold